

# Bank of Leeds Strategic Infrastructure Proposal

## Leeds Airport Renaissance Programme 2045

### Creating Yorkshire's International Airport and Northern England's Second Global Aviation Hub

**Prepared for:**

Bank of Leeds – Strategic Infrastructure Investment Division

**Investment Classification:**

Airport Infrastructure / High-Speed Transport / Regional Economic Development

**Proposed Investment Vehicle:**

## Yorkshire Aviation Growth Bond

**Indicative Investment Requirement:**

**£5 billion**

**Investment Horizon:**

20 years

---

## Executive Summary

The Bank of Leeds proposes the transformation of **Leeds Bradford Airport** into:

## Leeds International Airport

### The Airport of Yorkshire

The objective is to create a major international airport capable of competing with:

- Manchester Airport,
- Birmingham Airport,
- Edinburgh Airport.

The strategy is based on two linked investments:

1. **Major airport expansion**

## 2. A dedicated ultra-fast rail connection between Leeds city centre and the airport

The core idea:

"An airport is only as powerful as its connection to its city."

Manchester succeeded partly because of its integrated rail connection. Leeds currently lacks a direct airport railway connection, limiting its competitiveness. Existing airport growth plans already envisage significant expansion, with Leeds Bradford Airport targeting around **7 million passengers annually by 2030** supported by private investment.

The Bank of Leeds proposal would go further:

Create a:

# Yorkshire Global Gateway

serving:

- 5.5 million people in Yorkshire,
  - northern England,
  - international business,
  - tourism,
  - universities,
  - manufacturing exports.
- 

## Strategic Vision

### Rename:

Current:

**Leeds Bradford Airport**

Future:

## Leeds International Airport Yorkshire

or:

## Leeds Airport

---

Brand positioning:

"The international gateway for Yorkshire."

---

Comparable examples:

| <b>Airport</b>                           | <b>City Population Served</b> |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Manchester Airport                       | North West                    |
| Edinburgh Airport                        | Scotland                      |
| Copenhagen Airport                       | Scandinavia                   |
| Zurich Airport                           | Switzerland                   |
| Yorkshire currently lacks an equivalent. |                               |

---

# Current Position

Leeds Bradford Airport currently handles approximately **4 million passengers annually**, with recent investment programmes aimed at increasing capacity and improving facilities.

Manchester Airport handles approximately **28 million passengers annually**, demonstrating the scale gap between a regional airport and a major international hub.

The opportunity:

Move Leeds from:

**4 million passengers**

to:

**20 million passengers annually**

over 20 years.

---

# Investment Programme

## Total Investment

**£5 billion**

---

| <b>Component</b>              | <b>Cost</b> |
|-------------------------------|-------------|
| New airport terminal          | £1.5bn      |
| Runway and airfield expansion | £750m       |
| Cargo and logistics hub       | £500m       |
| Hotels/business district      | £500m       |
| Maglev airport link           | £1.5bn      |
| Land acquisition/environment  | £250m       |

---

# Part 1

## Leeds Airport Expansion

**Investment:**

**£3.5 billion**

---

## New Terminal

**Cost:**

£1.5bn

---

Create:

## Yorkshire International Terminal

Capacity:

20–25 million passengers/year

---

Facilities:

- 80+ departure gates
  - premium lounges
  - business facilities
  - automated security
  - luxury shopping district
- 

Airline target:

- Emirates
  - Qatar Airways
  - Singapore Airlines
  - United Airlines
  - Delta
  - Asian carriers
-

# Runway Expansion

## Cost:

£750m

---

### Works:

- runway improvements,
  - taxiways,
  - aircraft stands.
- 

### Objective:

### Support:

- long-haul aircraft,
  - cargo aircraft,
  - next-generation aircraft.
- 

# Cargo & Logistics Hub

## Cost:

£500m

---

### Create:

# Yorkshire Air Freight Zone

---

### Target industries:

- pharmaceuticals,
  - advanced manufacturing,
  - high-value engineering,
  - food exports.
- 

### Potential:

100,000 tonnes/year air freight.

---

# Airport City Development

## Cost:

£500m

---

Create:

## Leeds Airport Business District

Including:

- hotels,
  - offices,
  - conference centre,
  - logistics parks.
- 

Employment:

15,000 jobs.

---

## Part 2

## Leeds Airport Maglev Express

### The Yorkshire Airport Link

---

The signature project:

## Leeds City Centre → Leeds Airport in 7 minutes

---

Inspired by:

Shanghai Maglev Airport Link.

The Shanghai airport maglev operates a short dedicated route and demonstrates the possibility of ultra-fast airport-city connections.

---

# Proposed Route

Approximate distance:

15 km

---

Route:

Leeds City Station

↓

Leeds West End

↓

Horsforth

↓

Leeds Airport

---

## Technology

### Low-speed urban maglev

Not a 500km/h intercity system.

Designed for:

- airport transfer,
  - reliability,
  - frequency.
- 

Speed:

200–250 km/h

---

Journey:

Current:

35–50 minutes by road

Future:

## 7–10 minutes

---

# Maglev Cost Model

Shanghai's short maglev line cost roughly around \$1.3bn for 30.5km, though costs vary heavily depending on geography and design.

A Yorkshire version:

15km route

Estimated:

£1.5 billion

---

Breakdown:

| Component         | Cost  |
|-------------------|-------|
| Elevated guideway | £700m |
| Stations          | £300m |
| Rolling stock     | £250m |
| Power systems     | £150m |
| Land/contingency  | £100m |

---

## Passenger Forecast

Airport passengers:

20 million/year

Assume:

40% use rail.

Passengers:

8 million/year

---

Average ticket:

£15

Revenue:

## £120m/year

---

Additional commercial revenue:

- advertising,
- retail,



- property.
- 

## Total Transport Revenue:

£150m/year+

---

## Economic Impact

### Airport Growth

Moving from:

4 million passengers

to:

20 million passengers.

---

Additional passengers:

16 million/year

---

Average economic value:

£100 per passenger trip

---

Direct economic activity:

## £1.6 billion/year

---

## GDP Impact

Airport multiplier effects:

- tourism,
- exports,
- business travel,
- investment.

Estimated Yorkshire GDP uplift:

**£3–5 billion annually**

---

## **Employment Impact**

### **Airport Expansion**

Direct:

10,000 jobs

---

### **Airport City**

15,000 jobs

---

### **Supply Chain**

20,000 jobs

---

Total:

**45,000+ jobs**

---

## **Tourism Impact**

A major Yorkshire airport would transform:

### **York**

International tourism gateway.

---

### **Yorkshire Dales**

Global visitors.

---

## Sheffield

Business tourism.

---

## Hull

International trade links.

---

# New Long-Haul Routes

Potential destinations:

## North America

- New York
  - Toronto
  - Chicago
- 

## Middle East

- Dubai
  - Doha
  - Abu Dhabi
- 

## Asia

- Singapore
  - Tokyo
  - Shanghai
- 

## Europe

- Paris
  - Frankfurt
  - Madrid
  - Rome
-

# Financing Structure

## Bank of Leeds Yorkshire Aviation Bond

### £5 billion issue

---

Term:

40 years

---

Investors:

- pension funds,
  - sovereign wealth funds,
  - infrastructure investors.
- 

## Revenue Security

Backed by:

- airport fees,
  - passenger charges,
  - commercial property,
  - rail tickets,
  - retail income.
- 

## Financial Model

### Year 10

Passengers:

12 million

Revenue:

£700m/year

---

### Year 20

Passengers:

20 million

Revenue:

£1.5bn/year

---

Potential EBITDA:

£400–600m/year

---

## Property Upside

Airport City:

Estimated value:

**£2–3 billion**

---

Maglev corridor:

Potential development:

- offices,
  - hotels,
  - housing.
- 

## Delivery Timeline

### Phase 1: 2026–2032

£1.5bn

- terminal expansion,
  - planning,
  - airport upgrades.
- 

### Phase 2: 2032–2040

£2bn

- maglev construction,
  - cargo hub.
-

## Phase 3: 2040–2045

£1.5bn

- long-haul expansion,
  - Airport City.
- 

## Strategic Recommendation

The Bank of Leeds should establish:

## Leeds International Airport Development Corporation

with authority to:

- issue bonds,
  - invest in airport infrastructure,
  - develop surrounding land,
  - negotiate airline partnerships.
- 

## Final Investment Thesis

Yorkshire is one of Europe's largest economies without a globally competitive airport.

Manchester captures much of Yorkshire's aviation demand because of connectivity.

The strategic opportunity:

**Build Yorkshire its own international gateway.**

A £5 billion Bank of Leeds-backed programme would create:

- a 20 million passenger airport,
- a 7-minute city connection,
- tens of thousands of jobs,
- billions in GDP growth.

The vision:

**"Leeds Airport — Yorkshire's Gateway to the World."**